

Justice as entitlement



In response to Rawls's liberal definition of justice as fairness, Robert Nozick offered an alternative definition that better fitted his libertarian views. Justice, for Nozick, is a matter of entitlement. Influenced by the economic theories of Friedrich Hayek and the political philosophy of Locke, his entitlement theory has three main principles: justice in acquisition (how a person first comes to own property), justice in transfer (how a person can acquire property from another person with their consent, by trade or as a gift) and rectification of injustice (how to deal with property that is acquired or transferred unjustly). Distribution of property is just

when everyone is entitled to the property they possess: anyone who acquires property according to the principles of justice in acquisition or justice in transfer is entitled to it, but no one is entitled to property acquired in other ways, and rectification exists to deal with cases such as theft or fraud. State intervention should be limited to protection of entitlement, and redistribution without consent, for example through taxation, is unjust.